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Official Records

President: Mr. Kőrösi (Hungary)

The meeting was called to order at 10 a.m.

Agenda item 14 (continued)

Culture of peace

Report of the Secretary-General (A/77/614)

Draft resolution (A/77/L.74)

The President: Peace and respect for humankind across its great diversity are the central mission of the United Nations. Peace is elevated in Article I of the Charter of the United Nations as both a goal of our collective efforts and an essential tool for settling international disputes. It is at the heart of our 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and inherent to our ultimate sense of safety and well-being. This Agenda is designed to strengthen peace and requires peace for its successful implementation.

But today our core mission is under threat. Dozens of conflicts are raging around the globe. One in six of the world's 1.8 billion young people lives in a conflict setting, the highest number in 20 years. A staggering 100 million people have been displaced by violence — more than double the number a decade ago. Not one of us is spared from the effects of today's cascading crises — whether around food and climate, or energy and security.

It is therefore on all of us to work towards transformation. The arc of humankind is at an inflection point, and we simply must shift course — away from

confrontation to dialogue, from force to reason, from war to diplomacy and towards full respect for the United Nations Charter principles we have pledged to uphold.

As Dutch philosopher Baruch Spinoza wrote in 1670,

“Peace is not an absence of war, it is a virtue — a state of mind, a disposition for benevolence, confidence, justice”.

It is also “a set of values, attitudes, traditions, modes of behaviour and ways of life” that Member States agreed to cherish when they adopted the Declaration and Programme of Action on a Culture of Peace. Those values recognize our common humanity, respect sovereignty and independence, reject violence and uphold human rights. These are values of tolerance, solidarity and inclusion that help our societies concentrate the necessary resources on transformation — back at home and in our multilateral system. And let me confirm this — whoever thinks that war is a better way to achieve a country's ambitions than cooperation has no rightful place in our global community.

What will it take to forge peaceful coexistence among peoples, nations, cultures and religions? We need a renewed approach to peace that recognizes the epic scale of the challenges at hand. We must broaden our vision, breaking away from the old, narrow interpretation of interests. We need a vision where interests, rights and responsibilities go hand in hand. We should consciously work on rebuilding lost trust. And we need everyone to participate.

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That means the full inclusion of women in all processes to help prevent, mediate and resolve conflict, and to rebuild societies. It means critical investments in young people, in education and the fight against racism and intolerance. In the General Assembly, it means not allowing short-sighted views to get in the way of vital breakthroughs. It means opening our doors to those who can meaningfully contribute to our mission — civil society, scientists and experts.

The United Nations is an institution that embodies the notions of cooperation, understanding, good faith, and tolerance. It is where inclusive, open and genuine global dialogue should take place in order to give peace a chance and to create a just, equal, safe and sustainable world for all of us.

I now give the floor to the representative of Bangladesh to introduce draft resolution A/77/L.74.

Mr. Muhith (Bangladesh): I thank the President of the General Assembly for his very insightful remarks. Today I have the honour to introduce draft resolution entitled “Follow-up to the Declaration and Programme of Action on a Culture of Peace” (A/77/L.74).

This year the draft resolution was negotiated during the resumed session, allowing more time to the delegations to engage fully on a number of substantive updates. Those updates reflect the continued relevance of a culture of peace in the present-day context, which is defined by complex challenges and unlimited opportunities. Indeed, it is more urgent today than ever to promote a culture of peace and to prioritize dialogue and rapprochement over violence and confrontation.

The text before us represents a careful balance between comprehensive updating and modest streamlining, which my delegation intends to continue in the coming years. While presenting substantive language for this year’s text we remained mindful of the need to advance actions in all eight areas of the Declaration and Programme of Action on a Culture of Peace.

We sincerely thank all delegations for their active and constructive participation in the informal consultations. We deeply appreciate the spirit of flexibility shown by all and the valuable inputs, which have certainly enriched the draft resolution before us.

Some major additions introduced in this year’s text include the following.

First, there is a recognition of collective efforts in addressing global risks and challenges, with the United Nations playing the central role in accordance with its Charter and other key multilateral frameworks, such as the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. Taking into account the ongoing efforts to advance a multilateral solution to present and future problems, the text has included a reference to the report of the Secretary-General entitled *Our Common Agenda* (A/75/982) and its follow up processes, which offer new momentum to multilateralism.

Secondly, importance has been accorded to the promotion and strengthening of preventive diplomacy. In that regard, an open, constructive and respectful debate of ideas, as well as interreligious, interfaith and intercultural dialogue, have been encouraged at the local, national, regional and international levels with a view to advancing human fraternity, solidarity and tolerance. In doing so, the draft resolution has taken note of a number of initiatives that are taken by the United Nations, its entities, Member States, regional organizations and civil society.

Thirdly, there is reaffirmation of the invaluable role of women in the prevention and the resolution of conflicts and in activities promoting a culture of peace. The text stressed the importance of ensuring gender equality and the empowerment of women and girls, with the aim of advancing their full, equal and meaningful participation in such processes. The text has also recognized the role of youth in advancing peace through their meaningful participation across all pillars of the United Nations work.

Fourthly, there is a recognition of a gap in promoting a culture of peace in the context of the current digital sphere and its ongoing transformation. That has been included as an important area for global action in the field of the culture of peace.

Finally, the importance of addressing the underlying drivers of violence and conflict has been stressed. In order to free those who are languishing in protracted conflicts and through the cycle of violence, the text has encouraged Member States, the United Nations and other relevant actors to adopt a holistic approach to the cross-cutting dimensions of peace, development, humanitarian action and human rights in order to prevent the recurrence of conflict and build lasting peace.

In addition to those substantive updates, the text this year has proposed the biennialization of the report while maintaining annual consideration of the resolution.

The draft resolution welcomes the High-level Forum convened by the President of the Assembly, on 6 September 2022, on the theme “The Culture of Peace: Importance of justice, equality and inclusion for advancing peacebuilding”, which involved the participation of Member States, civil society and other stakeholders.

And, in keeping with past tradition, the draft resolution requests the President of the General Assembly to convene the annual high-level forum on the culture of peace in 2023. We look forward to working closely with the Office of the President of the General Assembly to make the event yet another success.

The initiative on the culture of peace began in 1999 as a set of values, attitudes, traditions and modes of behaviour and ways of life based on efforts to meet the development and environmental needs of present and future generations. A modest venture, it has over time, with the mandate of the Assembly, grown in relevance and evolved into a dominant theme finding larger footprints and recognition in all major United Nations discourses. In the rapidly changing global situation, it has proved to be a useful means to complement the obligations of the Charter of the United Nations of maintaining peace in the world.

The Assembly has endorsed, over the past 23 years, the enduring value of a culture of peace and adopted this flagship resolution by consensus. And today we expect the same strong endorsement from the Assembly.

We sincerely thank those delegations who have already sponsored the draft resolution, and we look forward to more delegations sponsoring from the floor ahead of its adoption, in order to send a strong message to the world of the United Nations abiding commitment to peace, to a culture of peace.

I wish to conclude by expressing our sincere appreciation to you, Mr. President, and your Office for your continued support to the follow-up to the Declaration and Programme of Action on a Culture of Peace.

Mr. Jackman (Barbados): I have the honour to deliver today’s statement on behalf of the 14 members States of the Caribbean Community (CARICOM). We thank you, Mr. President, for placing the focus squarely

on agenda item 14, “Culture of Peace”, and promoting interreligious and intercultural dialogue and cooperation.

At the outset, the Caribbean Community wishes to express its full support to Bangladesh for its continued dedication and its holistic, integrated and comprehensive approach to the follow-up to the Declaration of Action on the Culture of Peace. This is the epitome of the universal mandate of our international community, particularly the United Nations system — the promotion of a culture of peace and non-violence that benefits all humankind.

Given today’s global context, it is even more critical than before for us to build on the existing culture of peace and enshrined international cooperation and a functioning rules-based international order to combat global threats.

As a region of cultural diversity, CARICOM recognizes that there is a need for us to build a grand alliance for a culture of peace among all, particularly with proactive involvement and participation of women and youth. Furthermore, we believe that global efforts towards peace and reconciliation can be sustained only with a collective approach built on trust, constructive dialogue and collaboration.

As stated in the Declaration on a Culture of Peace, education at all levels is one of the principal means to build a culture of peace. The most significant way of promoting a culture of peace is through education. CARICOM believes that premise remains true. In addition, when women and youth are engaged, peace is possible. Through our Caribbean Youth Advocacy and Action Agenda on Violence Prevention, we have actively engaged and empowered our youth across our region. That has allowed our youth to effectively work on specific issues related to crime and violence, including the prevention and the reduction of crime, to foster social inclusion and to promote reintegration.

CARICOM sincerely believes that peace is a prerequisite for us to achieve prosperity and sustainable development. It is much more than simply the absence of war.

A comprehensive and coordinated approach to the promotion of a culture of peace is an imperative dimension of international commitment towards promoting mutual understanding and cooperation to achieve global peace. CARICOM remains committed to being part of that process.

Mr. Pérez Ayestarán (Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela) (*spoke in Spanish*): The Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela has the honour to take the floor on behalf of the Group of Friends in Defence of the Charter of the United Nations.

What remains of 2023 looks set to be a year of immense challenges for the global agenda, given the current multifaceted crisis the world is facing: the economic and financial crisis, inflation on a global scale, unequal food production and distribution, rising energy prices, the high cost of reconstruction after the coronavirus disease and the threat of new pandemics and the increase in natural catastrophes due to climate change, all of which only exacerbates human suffering and increases poverty and exclusion. Added to that is an alarming increase in the application and expansion of the scope of unilateral coercive measures, which ultimately threaten multilateralism as a whole.

All those tragedies have human origins, with a lack of dialogue and cooperation at the core and with selfish interests prevailing. The only possible way to overcome those challenges is to strengthen a robust tradition of a culture of peace and solidarity. That will lead to peaceful coexistence, respect for differences and mutual attempts to accommodate one another in the fight against common challenges.

The States members of our Group of Friends believe that the promotion of a culture of peace must consequently be an absolute priority in our common endeavours.

The meaning and intrinsic values of that culture compel States and other global actors to actively promote and encourage the creation of spaces in which we can build political trust and foster truly inclusive economic development.

We must also actively promote dialogue based on mutual respect, tolerance, peaceful coexistence, active non-violence and intercultural and interreligious dialogue, and we must implement policies that foster more egalitarian and equitable societies — societies in which policies of inclusion that benefit those potentially most vulnerable are put into place. We must guarantee greater access to health care and education, which must always be viewed as a human right, not as a commodity. We must bring about a world without hunger and achieve a truly just and equitable new international order, one without racism, racial discrimination, xenophobia, extremism or any other form of intolerance. We must

usher in a new world order in which people live in ongoing harmony with nature, in which cultural diversity is both embraced and granted the status of a historically valuable entity because it enriches and strengthens our societies.

The culture of peace is synonymous with and encompasses, inter alia, the self-determination and sovereignty of our peoples, egalitarian economic and social development, and respect for human rights without distinction made based on class or categories. It involves working without politicization, instrumentalization or double standards of any kind. It also includes universal social justice, health care and education for all, non-interference in the internal affairs of States, cultural diversity and the creation of a world based on the values and ideals that inspired the establishment of the United Nations, values that today are at risk of being watered down by the proliferation of extremist tendencies.

Against that backdrop, we take this opportunity to reject hegemonistic and unilateral policies that affect international peace, security and stability. Those policies represent a clear attempt to undermine the purposes and principles enshrined in the Charter of the United Nations and the efforts under way towards the democratization of international relations and the strengthening of multilateralism and of a multipolar system, which are based, inter alia, on mutual respect for the sovereignty and territorial integrity of all States and respect for the principles of the equal rights and self-determination of peoples, the rule of law, diplomacy, political dialogue, tolerance, peaceful coexistence, respect for diversity, inclusion, a culture of peace and non-violence and due consideration for existing differences.

All those values are vital if we are to constructively and effectively work together on issues of common interest and concern. It is the staunch conviction of the Group of Friends that in order to achieve those lofty, value-based aspirations, it is imperative to promote, preserve and staunchly defend the purposes and principles enshrined in the Charter of the United Nations. We must do so on the basis of a spirit of inclusivity and respect for national sovereignty, the legal equality of States, the peaceful resolution of disputes, social progress and the promotion of a revitalized and truly inclusive multilateralism.

Consequently, we deem it an international political priority to defend the institutional essence provided by

the tenets contained in our founding Charter, which have preserved global peace over the past 77 years and are currently under systematic attack by those intent on weakening the multilateral system, including the United Nations, and fostering instead unilateral practices and proclivities. As such, we believe that only with the promotion of confidence-building measures and an ongoing continued, constructive and genuine dialogue among all actors in a society will it be possible to build and sustain the foundations that will ultimately lead us to the advent of a peaceful and prosperous world for current and future generations.

Climate change, endemic poverty and inequality, uncontrolled human mobility, transnational organized crime and terrorism, for example, will never be overcome without a dynamic multilateralism in which agendas based on exceptionalist and unilateral ambitions are dismantled, bearing in mind that those scourges know no borders, nor do they spare elites from their tragic consequences. Consequently, we advocate greater global awareness of the need for dialogue and understanding among cultures, political ideologies, religions and civilizations, so as to bring about a genuine and sustained peace based on justice and coexistence.

The culture of peace is based, *inter alia*, on the sovereign equality of States, which are the international actors par excellence in the promotion of dialogue and cooperation among nations. Consequently, it is vital that without delay we repeal any unilateral coercive economic or political measures that affect the individual and collective rights of millions of people, increase poverty and inequality, restrict access to essential goods and foster perpetual wars and conflict in contravention of the very principles set out in the Charter of the United Nations.

Moreover, we deem it urgent to actively counter disinformation, counter-information and hate speech, which in recent times have been used by unscrupulous groups to sow discord and create social conflict and constant anxiety through the dissemination of fake news, the exacerbation of ideological or religious differences and the promotion of attacks against potentially vulnerable groups and sectors, thereby creating a breeding ground for violent extremism leading to terrorism and for the promotion of expressions of fascism, Nazism, neo-Nazism and racial supremacy, as well as discrimination against Africans and Asians and their descendants. Those are all extremist ideologies

that we thought had already been overcome long ago by humankind.

In conclusion, our Group of Friends reaffirms its commitment to continuing its efforts to create formulas and effective means to combat intolerance and to working with the United Nations in order to promote the values of and the effective implementation of the Declaration and Programme of Action on a Culture of Peace. We remain committed, moreover, to resolutely promoting intercultural and interreligious dialogue as well as active non-violence, condemning hate speech and decisively promoting dialogue and peaceful diplomacy as a concrete means of achieving the ideal of a world characterized by genuine coexistence — an ideal that we will never give up on, despite the adversities that the world is facing today.

Ms. Sulaiman (Brunei Darussalam): I am honoured to deliver this statement on behalf of the members of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN).

At the outset, ASEAN would like to express its appreciation to the Secretary-General for his report (A/77/614) under this agenda item. We are particularly pleased to see the continued efforts of the United Nations towards the promotion of a culture of peace as well as interreligious and intercultural dialogue and cooperation.

South-East Asia is a region home to 640 million people with a variety of ethnicities, religions, languages and cultures. In recognition of unity in diversity and the benefits of fostering a culture of peace, good understanding, good-neighbourliness and meaningful cooperation, those core principles were enshrined in the Bangkok Declaration of 1967, and more than five decades on ASEAN continues its endeavours to ensure peace, progress and prosperity in the region.

The adoption of the Declaration on Culture of Prevention for a Peaceful, Inclusive, Resilient, Healthy and Harmonious Society by ASEAN leaders at the thirty-first ASEAN Summit, held in 2017, is one such endeavour, which aims to build a culture of prevention to address the root causes of violent extremism and other forms of violence; social issues such as the displacement of populations; and destabilizing factors such as poverty and inequality.

ASEAN's Plan of Action on Culture of Prevention sets out six thrusts, namely, promoting a culture of peace and intercultural understanding; promoting a culture of respect for all; promoting a culture of

good governance at all levels; promoting a culture of resilience and care for the environment; promoting a culture of healthy lifestyles; and promoting a culture supporting the values of moderation.

Those guiding principles remain relevant and anchor ASEAN's continued efforts to realize that vision, including the adoption in 2021 of the ASEAN Strategic Policy Framework on Promoting an Adaptive ASEAN Community of Greater Understanding, Tolerance and a Sense of Regional Agendas among Peoples of ASEAN.

Following the implementation of the Strategic Framework, ASEAN has issued a Strategy Playbook on Promoting an Adaptive ASEAN Community of Greater Understanding, Tolerance and a Sense of Regional Agendas among Peoples of ASEAN. The development of that playbook was informed by three strategic outcomes, namely, first, a cohesive, tolerant and caring community supported by an enhanced whole-of-ASEAN nexus approach; secondly, a future-proofed culture that is responsive, resilient, gender-sensitive, inclusive and prepared by mainstreaming greater understanding, tolerance and a sense of awareness of regional agendas in regional policy considerations and activity implementation; and, thirdly, a dynamic, sustainable and inclusive ecosystem of stakeholders to foster greater understanding, tolerance and a sense of regional agendas' value-centric ASEAN identity and communities through the forging of partnerships.

We hope that the issuance of that document will bring us closer to realizing the vision of promoting ASEAN as an adaptive community of opportunities for all that celebrates diversity, tolerance and inclusivity.

In addition to intra-ASEAN initiatives, engaging our dialogue partners and other partners across the globe is critical to promoting a culture of peace, security, stability and prosperity, including through key instruments such as the Treaty of Amity and Cooperation in Southeast Asia and the Treaty on the Southeast Asia Nuclear Weapon-Free Zone, as well as ASEAN-led mechanisms such as the East Asia Summit, the ASEAN Regional Forum and the ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting-Plus.

Furthermore, ASEAN's cooperation with the United Nations forms part of that nexus of regional and global partnership. The Plan of Action to Implement the Joint Declaration on Comprehensive Partnership between ASEAN and the United Nations (2021-2025) covers a wide range of shared strategic priorities, activities and

measures that include technical cooperation to exchange expertise, best practices, lessons learned in countering terrorism and radicalization as well as preventing violent extremism. ASEAN also continues to support the Security Council's women and peace and security agenda as well as the youth, peace and security agenda.

Recognizing the important roles of women and young people in peacebuilding, peace processes and conflict resolution, ASEAN convened an ASEAN Regional Forum Symposium Building on Lessons Learned from the Women, Peace and Security and the Youth, Peace and Security Agendas from 28 to 30 June 2022.

ASEAN also welcomes the invaluable role of the United Nations Alliance of Civilizations in promoting intercultural and interreligious dialogue and greater understanding and respect among civilizations, cultures, religions and beliefs. We would also like to express our congratulations to Morocco for having successfully hosted the ninth Global Forum last November in the city of Fez.

We recognize the Alliance's role in developing the United Nations Plan of Action to Safeguard Religious Sites and support its call for mutual respect, which stresses that the freedom of religion or belief and freedom of expression are interdependent, interrelated and mutually reinforcing rights rooted in the Universal Declaration of Human Rights.

In a time beset by interlocking challenges, ASEAN will continue to do its part in contributing towards global peace, security and prosperity through multilateralism, mutual respect, tolerance, acceptance, reconciliation and upholding the rule of law.

In conclusion, I wish to reaffirm ASEAN's readiness to work with partners in the international community and the United Nations towards maintaining global peace and stability so as to build more inclusive and prosperous societies for everyone.

Mr. Wong (Singapore): Singapore aligns itself with the statement delivered by the representative of Brunei Darussalam on behalf of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations and adds the following points in our national capacity.

My delegation thanks the Secretary-General for his comprehensive report (A/77/614) on promoting a culture of peace and interreligious and intercultural dialogue. A culture of peace built upon strong and connected

communities remains fundamental to a resilient, stable and prosperous world.

Just as the world is emerging from the coronavirus disease pandemic, we face new headwinds of rising global tensions and growing inequality. In many countries, our social fabric is being put to the test. Misinformation and disinformation, amplified in today's digital age, threaten to widen fault lines within societies. It may be tempting, in these circumstances, to retreat further into insularism. However, more than ever we need to pursue collective action to deal with those challenges.

Collective action and achieving social cohesion are not spontaneous occurrences. That is a hard-won lesson that Singapore knows all too well. A 2021 Pew Research Centre survey reported that Singapore, while ethnically and racially diverse, was one of the least divided societies surveyed. That is a far cry from Singapore's turbulent 1950s and 1960s, when intercommunal tension boiled over into riots. Every step to get to where we are today has been deliberate and considered. We have enshrined multiracialism into our Constitution, recognizing all persons as equal before the law and prohibiting discrimination on the grounds of religion and race. Multiracialism has also shaped many of our major national policies, with deliberate policies to ensure that no race is excluded or disadvantaged in fields spanning education, housing, and politics.

We were proud to ratify the International Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Racial Discrimination in 2017 and presented our initial report to the Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination in November 2021.

Articles 6 and 8 of the Declaration on a Culture of Peace recognize that not only Governments but also civil societies and religious groups play an important role in the full development of peace. That is something that we recognize in Singapore as well. Twenty years ago, Singapore established the Inter-Racial and Religious Confidence Circles (IRCCs), a platform for community and religious leaders to have regular interactions to foster friendships and build trust.

Singapore will refresh the programmes of the IRCCs as well as renew and expand their composition, and it will rebrand them as Racial and Religious Harmony Circles. We also continue to foster other avenues for dialogue, including with the broader international community. In September 2022, Singapore hosted

the second International Conference on Cohesive Societies, at the initiative of our President. It was attended by more than 800 participants from more than 40 countries and various spheres, including religious leaders, policymakers, academics and members of civil society. The second edition put the spotlight on the critical role of youth leadership in promoting social cohesion and on how technology can be used to bring together instead of divide communities.

We can and must continue to find strength in diversity and build bridges among communities to foster a culture of peace. Singapore wholeheartedly supports the Secretary-General's efforts to promote a global culture of peace and will continue working with the international community towards that common goal.

Mr. Al Khalil (Syrian Arab Republic) (*spoke in Arabic*): At the outset, my country's delegation aligns itself with the statement delivered by the representative of Venezuela on behalf of the Group of Friends in Defence of the Charter of the United Nations and would like to make the following remarks in our national capacity.

My delegation has read the report of the Secretary-General under consideration (A/77/614) and takes note of the efforts of United Nations entities to promote a culture of peace and non-violence.

The Syrian Arab Republic believes that peace lies in understanding, respect and tolerance among religions, cultures and peoples. The establishment of a culture of peace will be possible only on the basis of respect for international law, the Charter of the United Nations and the resolutions of international legitimacy. The adoption of the Declaration and Programme of Action on a Culture of Peace seeks to establish and enshrine that culture at the international and national levels.

Unfortunately, there are many challenges in that regard, including the spread of terrorism and violent extremism, acts of violence and hate speech and other phenomena that undermine international peace and security in our common world.

The challenges facing the maintenance of international peace and security make it imperative for all of us to put the culture of peace into practice, so that it does not remain only theory and resolutions and so that we can ensure that there is a collective will to establish and promote human communication that is free from the practices of exclusion, isolation and discrimination, in a way that prioritizes the values of

dialogue, cooperation, the acceptance of others and coexistence and puts an end to the policies of hegemony, aggression, the usurpation of rights and the occupation of the lands of others.

Establishing a culture of peace requires translating words into actions through enhancing the principles of the Charter, so that we can put an end to the practice of some countries using the mechanisms of our common work to target certain countries through twisted interpretations of some of the Articles of the Charter, the use of double standards and the politicization of humanitarian issues or the actions taken by certain countries to impose their will on the international community. We see that in the unilateral coercive measures whose consequences are causing many peoples, including the Syrian people, to suffer.

My country stresses also the need to urgently and decisively address the growing trend of radicalization and the increase in hate speech, racism, stigma, stereotyping, contempt for religion and xenophobia, especially against migrants and refugees.

Those obstacles will continue to obstruct the path to the culture of peace to which we aspire, deepen the divide among peoples and weaken trust in the performance of our Organization at a time when many of our peoples are still paying a hefty price for colonialism, intervention, military invasions, terrorist wars and illegal criminal alliances, with acts of aggression undermining the significant developmental achievements made in many of the developing countries.

In conclusion, we look forward to our joint efforts in the development of implementable solutions that enhance the practice of peace and are in line with the principles of primacy and respect for national sovereignty, taking into account the fact that the culture of peace is organically linked to the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and is a main pillar of the achievement of international peace and security.

Mr. Dai Bing (China) (*spoke in Chinese*): China associates itself with the statement made by the representative of Venezuela on behalf of the Group of Friends in Defence of the Charter of the United Nations.

China also co-sponsored draft resolution A/77/L.74, sponsored by Bangladesh.

The world today faces multiple interconnected challenges and crises, with the global economy struggling to recover, the development gap widening

and the ghost of the cold-war mentality lingering. Human society has once again come to a crossroads in history, and thus that backdrop promoting the culture of peace is of realistic significance.

China would like to touch on the following three points.

First, there is a need to narrow the trust deficit to create the conditions for peace. What lies behind the complex issues facing the world is a long-accumulated deficit in trust. In his report (A/77/614), the Secretary-General also urgently calls for building trust among nations and peoples; however, deepening mutual trust is easier said than done. The key is to adhere to such values as mutual respect, peaceful coexistence and win-win cooperation to uphold international equity and justice and to practice true multilateralism.

A small number of countries are stoking confrontation under the pretext of democracy, creating division in the name of risk removal, practicing exceptionalism and double standards and engaging in hegemonic practices and bullying. Such practices will only undermine mutual trust, with continuing repercussions.

Mr. Wallace (Jamaica), Vice-President, took the Chair.

Secondly, we must promote peace through development so as to lay a solid foundation for peace. In both the United Nations sustainable development agenda and the Secretary-General's *Our Common Agenda* (A/75/982), development is viewed as an important means for eliminating the root causes of conflicts and achieving lasting peace. The international community should take that seriously and increase investment in development and uphold the concepts of solidarity, cooperation and common development, pay attention to the special difficulties faced by developing countries and ensure the equitable sharing of development benefits by all countries.

A small number of countries have deliberately practiced decoupling and the breaking of chains, built high barriers for isolation purposes and suppressed the development of other countries in pursuit of their own development privileges. That runs counter to the global trend of development and progress and is doomed to failure.

Thirdly, strengthening inclusivity and mutual learning among civilizations and improving the links among peoples is key. In a globalized world, the future of

all countries is closely linked, and humankind belongs to a community with a shared future. We support the inclusive coexistence of cultures, encourage exchanges and mutual learning among civilizations, welcome empathy and joint efforts by peoples in the face of common challenges.

A small number of countries impose their values and morals on others and stoke ideological confrontation, which has seriously eroded the cornerstone of mutual understanding and cooperation among civilizations and runs counter to global efforts towards the culture of peace. Those countries will ultimately find themselves isolated.

President Xi Jinping recently put forward the Global Civilization initiative, which advocates for respect for the diversity of civilizations, the promotion of the shared values of humankind, continued innovation by civilizations and the enhancement of international personal and cultural exchanges and cooperation.

The Global Civilization Initiative, together with the Global Development Initiative and the Global Security Initiative, have become important public goods provided by China to the world in the new era, offering Chinese wisdom to resolve difficult global issues and promote peace, development and progress for humankind. All parties are welcome to actively join our initiatives, which are geared towards building a community with a shared future for humankind.

Mr. Hermida Castillo (Nicaragua) (*spoke in Spanish*): Nicaragua welcomes the convening of this meeting on the topic of the culture of peace. We align ourselves with the statement made by the delegation of Venezuela on behalf of the Group of Friends in Defence of the Charter of the United Nations.

We also express our recognition and thanks to the delegation of Bangladesh for its leadership in introducing the draft resolution entitled “Follow-up to the Declaration and Programme of Action on a Culture of Peace” (A/77/L.74), which we will be adopting at this meeting. Nicaragua is pleased to co-sponsor the draft resolution.

We are at a historic juncture in a changing world, and all of us have a responsibility to look after one another and to safeguard our Mother Earth, our cultures, our languages and our ways of life from the constant threat of extinction and from those who would attempt to subjugate and dominate us all in order to preserve a model that oppresses all cultures and ensure

that their supremacy prevails — which we, the peoples of the world, do not accept.

Our world is quickly moving towards multipolarity, with irreversible trends towards political, social, economic and cultural integration through mechanisms for unconditional, solidarity-based cooperation, greater investment and openness in trade to non-traditional markets, contributing to bringing about a holistic culture of peace among brotherly countries and peoples.

As a factor contributing to that multipolarity, the culture of peace becomes a crucial element in the development of such a world, based on the purposes and principles of the Charter of the United Nations and international law. Those include respect for sovereignty, non-interference in the domestic affairs of States, non-discrimination and absolute sovereign equality based on universal values such as peace, development, equality, social justice, democracy and freedom. We must also at all times prioritize negotiation and mutual understanding as well as mutually beneficial cooperation. We must call for an end to conflicts and acts of aggression and to the illegal unilateral coercive measures imposed on our peoples.

We urgently appeal for a greater global commitment to a genuine multilateralism, one that promotes cooperation and joint endeavours to tackle all our current challenges, including those that are rooted in social, economic and environmental inequalities within and among countries.

We note that the Secretary-General’s report on the promotion of a culture of peace (A/77/614) presents an overall snapshot of the actions undertaken by Member States and the United Nations system as a whole to promote a culture of peace. However, the report fails to mention, among the many challenges currently hampering the promotion of a culture of peace, the deliberate impact of the imperialist and neocolonialist practices of some States, which impose illegal unilateral coercive and arbitrary measures against peoples and Governments that exercise and defend their right to national sovereignty, independence and self-determination.

Nicaragua, as part of its culture of peace, continues, along with the international community, to defend multilateralism, building relations based on respect, equality, solidarity and mutual cooperation, abiding by and upholding the principles contained in the Charter of the United Nations, which include respect for

international law and non-interference in the domestic affairs of States.

We advocate for a just multipolar world that is equitable and based on solidarity, one that reduces poverty and inequalities throughout the world. We will continue to staunchly defend peace, and we will continue to implement our model of Christian development, which is socialist and solidarity-based, with a view to ensuring the well-being of our families and communities.

For that reason, we demand the immediate cessation of all coercive economic actions and measures, be they unilateral, bilateral or multilateral and regardless of which country they are imposed on. We champion the right of all peoples to decide their future without interference of any type.

As a people that cherishes and defends the establishment, preservation and defence of peace, our National Assembly on 19 April declared a National Day of Peace, reiterating the commitment of the Nicaraguan people and the Government of Reconciliation and National Unity to achieving a peace with dignity, a sovereign peace, a peace without foreign interference and an unconditional peace.

Mr. Akram (Pakistan): The Pakistan delegation welcomes the consideration of this important item on the culture of peace. We thank the Secretary-General for the report contained in document A/77/614, and we thank the President of the General Assembly for his opening remarks.

Pakistan welcomes and has co-sponsored the draft resolution submitted by Bangladesh (A/77/L.74), which has just been introduced by the Permanent Representative of Bangladesh.

As outlined in article 3 of the United Nations Declaration on Culture of Peace, the realization of a culture of peace is integrally linked to the central purposes of the Charter of the United Nations: that is, the non-use of force, respect for the sovereignty and territorial integrity of States, the recognition of the right of peoples to self-determination, the pacific settlement of disputes and the elimination of racial or religious discrimination, xenophobia and related intolerance.

Humankind encompasses diverse cultures and civilizations, which have come into progressively closer contact as the communications and information revolutions have contracted the world. The multicultural interac-

tions of different languages, foods, customs and beliefs have successfully enriched each culture, community and State. Greater intercultural understanding has helped to liberate peoples, end wars and promote peace and cooperation.

Unfortunately, there is a dark side to the closer contact of cultures and civilizations, as manifested in the historical and current instances of hostility, discrimination, hate and violence based on differences of race, religion, ethnicity, nationality and culture. History has frequently witnessed mass crimes and atrocities against the “other” in pogroms, wars, oppression and foreign occupation.

Despite the bitter lessons of the last century and the endeavours of the United Nations and many peoples and Governments of goodwill, recent times have witnessed a significant rise in hate, discrimination, xenophobia and organized violence against individuals, communities and nations owing to differences among cultures, nationalities, religions or races. The most adverse development in that context is the proliferation of Islamophobia and anti-Muslim hate and hostility, especially after the terrorist attacks of 9/11.

Anti-Muslim discrimination is pervasive in several non-Muslim countries. Islamophobic attitudes have justified societal discrimination and violence against Muslims. Worse, several instances of military intervention in which hundreds of thousands of Muslims perished would not have happened if Islamophobia had not influenced perceptions and decisions. The world is dealing with the consequences of several such Islamophobic mistakes. The resolution of the consequent conflicts and tensions in Asia and Africa will require the active promotion of a culture of peace.

Resolution 76/254, adopted last year, proclaimed 15 March — the day of the Christchurch massacre of 55 innocent Muslims — as the Day to Combat Islamophobia was most timely and essential. We look forward to developing, along with the Secretary-General, a plan of action to combat Islamophobia. In such a plan of action, the international community cannot fail to address the worst contemporary manifestation of Islamophobia — the threat posed by Hindutva hate in India against the 200 million Indian Muslims and Christians as well as the oppressed Muslims of occupied Jammu and Kashmir.

A century after the rise of fascism in Europe, which devastated the continent, the world is witnessing the rise of another State imbued with a similar ideology,

Hindutva, and similar practices of racially and religiously driven oppression and aggression against minorities. It is no accident that Hindutva, prescribing Hindu supremacy, was born simultaneously with Nazism in the 1920s.

The exponents of Hindutva — the so-called Sangh Parivar, or the family of Hindu organizations — adhere to an ideology of Hindu supremacy. They seek to transform India into an exclusive Hindu State in which Muslims and other minorities are obliged to convert to Hinduism or accept ejection or a second-class existence.

The founders of that party — the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), the parent of the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party — proudly equated their ideology with that of Hitler's Nazis and called for the persecution of India's Muslims just like that of the Jews. As Arundhati Roy, the Indian author, has observed, none of the modern-day white supremacists' neo-Nazi groups can boast the infrastructure and size of the RSS — with 57,000 branches, or what they call shakhas, and an armed and dedicated militia of 600,000 volunteers.

One of the members of the RSS, Nathuram Godse, assassinated Mahatma Gandhi. Within India's ruling party today, it is Godse, not Gandhi, who is glorified as a deity.

The RSS is responsible for the organized pogroms against Indian Muslims in Bombay in 1992, in Gujarat in 2002 and in Delhi in 2021. The BBC documentary on the Gujarat pogrom and the Indian Prime Minister's culpability in that massacre was banned in India, and the BBC is being investigated for tax fraud.

The RSS and the Sangh Parivar were responsible for the destruction in 1992 of the historic Babri mosque in Ayodha and the construction, with judicial complicity, of a Hindu temple on the site. Thousands of other mosques are threatened with destruction by Hindu zealots. The United Nations Alliance of Civilizations must take action, in accordance with its mandate, to protect those Islamic shrines. The United Nations must demand that the Indian Government halt its programme to eliminate India's Islamic heritage by changing history books, place names, school curricula and other similar cultural obliterations of Islam.

India must also be prevented from reducing its Muslims to statelessness through the discriminatory Citizenship Law and the National Registry List. India must halt the daily atrocities against Muslims

such as the lynching of Muslims by "cow vigilantes"; the detention of Muslims on the ridiculous charge of "love-jihad"; and violence against Christians for the "crime" of proselytizing.

Hindutva extremism is also turbocharging India's repression in occupied Jammu and Kashmir. It has deployed 900,000 troops — one soldier for every eight Kashmiri people — to impose its colonial annexation of Kashmir, resorting to extra-judicial killings; the abduction of 15,000 Kashmiri boys; collective punishment; and the incarceration of the entire political leadership of the All Parties Hurriyat Conference — the true voice of the Kashmiri people. India is implementing its strategy to transform occupied Jammu and Kashmir from a Muslim-majority State into a Hindu-majority territory, in violation of Security Council resolutions and international humanitarian law.

Pakistan has circulated a detailed dossier documenting, with evidence, more than 3,432 war crimes committed by Indian officials in occupied Jammu and Kashmir. The Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights has issued two reports citing massive human rights violations and proposed the establishment of a commission of inquiry to investigate those violations, asking for access to occupied Jammu and Kashmir. More than a dozen Special Rapporteurs of the Human Rights Council have expressed similar concerns about the human rights violations in occupied Kashmir and sought access to investigate those violations. None have been provided access, even as India has held stage-managed Group of 20 events in occupied Jammu and Kashmir to project a false normalcy there. As the United Nations Special Rapporteur on Minority Issues, Fernand de Varennes, stated on 15 May, by holding the G-20 meeting in occupied Kashmir, "the Government of India is seeking to normalize...military occupation". He added that "the situation in Jammu and Kashmir should be decried and condemned, not pushed under the rug".

Adama Dieng, the former Special Adviser to the Secretary-General on Genocide, used to say that "atrocities do not happen overnight" Gregory Stanton, the head of Genocide Watch, has warned that what is happening in Indian-occupied Jammu and Kashmir and in India itself points to the possibility of genocide in Kashmir and in India.

We urge those who are ready today to open their doors to the Prime Minister of India to call for a halt to India's oppression and atrocities. Their silence

diminishes their stature and exposes their vocal commitments to universal human values and human rights as being hollow and hypocritical.

Mr. Mohammad (Kuwait) (*spoke in Arabic*): At the outset, I would like to extend my sincere thanks to the Secretary-General, Mr. António Guterres, for his report (A/77/614) before us, which reviews the measures taken by Member States and the Organization to promote the culture of peace and dialogue among religions and defines the challenges facing international and regional efforts and endeavours to spread the culture of peace.

We endorse the Secretary-General's recommendations contained in that report, which stress the need to continue making efforts to promote the culture of peace and dialogue among religions and cultures in order to deal with the root causes of violence and conflict. It is also important to adopt comprehensive approaches that address the various dimensions of building peace, humanitarian work, human rights and development. We believe that the culture of peace should be based on a better understanding of the main motives behind the rise of conflicts and their continuation.

Our world today faces many interrelated, interlinked and intertwined tensions and crises. Acts of violence and instability plague many parts of the world. Many of them can be attributed to the rise of various forms of racism and an increase in hate speech and discrimination. The spread of such phenomena is the concern of all and adds to the complexity of others that the world has suffered for decades, even centuries, including intolerance, not accepting the other, bigotry, violent extremism, religious and factional strife, exclusion and the rejection of coexistence, all of which represent challenges that undermine and threaten the spread of a culture of peace in our societies and States.

Facing those challenges requires that we make every effort at the national, regional and international levels to transform a culture of hate, bigotry and war into a culture of dialogue, coexistence and peace. We must therefore take tangible and effective measures to address and limit hate speech, including Islamophobia, and to promote dialogue among religions and cultures, respect human rights and support peacebuilding efforts. We also stress the important role of women and young people in strengthening the culture of peace, particularly the need to enable and involve them in all fields, including political processes.

The promotion of peace is closely linked to sustainable development. A commitment to peace is vital to realizing the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and its Goal 16, on the promotion of peaceful and inclusive societies for all. In that context, we would like to stress that there can be no sustainable peace without development and no development without sustainable peace, as both are closely interlinked.

The culture of peace has deep roots in my country. The spirit of tolerance, dialogue and interaction with various cultures, religions and civilizations has been deeply established in the history of Kuwaiti society for hundreds of years. Those values have been translated in our contemporary age into a Constitution that guarantees the freedoms of opinion, expression, belief and practice of religious rights. In addition, our State founders clearly and explicitly stipulated in our Constitution that for the State of Kuwait peace is a State objective, thus establishing a peaceful approach to all endeavours undertaken by my country at the regional and international levels through our balanced, moderate and reasonable diplomacy.

In conclusion, the State of Kuwait stresses the importance of making every effort internationally aimed at promoting the culture of peace, a dialogue among civilizations and the spread of the values of moderation, tolerance and mutual respect, so as to ensure the renunciation of extremism, hatred and violence in all their forms through international and multilateral efforts, particularly through the United Nations, which was established to embrace and entrench dialogue as a steadfast principle in international relations towards achieving peace, cooperation and communication among nations and peoples.

Mr. Hilale (Morocco) (*spoke in French*): Allow me at the outset to thank President Kőrösi for having convened this annual debate on the culture of peace. I take this opportunity also to thank the Secretary-General for his report entitled "Promotion of a culture of peace" (A/77/614).

I wish also to congratulate Bangladesh for having introduced draft resolution A/77/L.74, entitled "Follow-up to the Declaration and Programme of Action on a Culture of Peace", which Morocco has always co-sponsored and supported.

A culture of peace is the *raison d'être* of our Organization. It is founded on the promotion of political understanding and constructive dialogue among States

on the basis of mutual respect and in line with the purposes and principles of the Charter of the United Nations. It embodies the three pillars that guide United Nations action – development, peace and security, and human rights.

In that context, I wish to reiterate the full support of my country for United Nations efforts to make the promotion of a culture of peace and dialogue among religions and cultures a central focus of the United Nations system as a whole.

In line with the instructions and guidance from His Majesty King Mohammed VI, the Kingdom of Morocco is a tireless advocate in the promotion of the values of peace and dialogue among religions and cultures, as well as mutual respect, human dignity and good-neighbourliness. We also attach great importance to the fight against all forms of discrimination, xenophobia, hatred and the rejection of the other, including Islamophobia, antisemitism and Christianophobia.

To address the numerous challenges that our world is currently facing, particularly the rise in ideological conflicts, intolerance, inward-looking attitudes, populism, violence, extremism and separatism, the Kingdom of Morocco, as an active, committed and responsible player on the international stage, is convinced that strengthening multilateralism and consistent collective action within our Organization to foster dialogue, pluralism and mutual respect are more crucial than ever.

The Kingdom of Morocco is working tirelessly to remain a model State in which, in a climate of fraternity and security, people of various monotheistic regions can coexist. My country is a crossroads and a melting pot of various cultures, religions and civilizations. Indeed, for centuries now Muslims, Jews and Christians have coexisted in our Kingdom. Morocco generously hosted and protected the thousands of Muslims and Jews who fled the Iberian peninsula to escape religious persecution in the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries.

Respect for cultural and religious diversity is a key tenet of the day-to-day life and collective consciousness of Moroccan society. The Kingdom of Morocco is also working tirelessly to strengthen the values of peace, harmony, growth and respect for cultural diversity at the national, regional and international levels, under the guidance of his Highness King Mohammed VI.

Here I would recall the historic visit of Pope Francis to Morocco on 30 and 31 March 2019, at the

invitation of His Majesty the King, Commander of the Faithful — the second visit, following that of Pope John Paul II, in 1985 — which is clear and eloquent testimony to the key role played by Morocco in promoting dialogue, understanding and cooperation among different religions and cultures.

Morocco attaches great importance to education, which we view as a basic, key element to ensure the development and maintenance of a culture of peace and to tackle the scourges of discrimination, hate and extremism. The educational system in Morocco teaches, from an early age, respect for open-mindedness, diversity and human rights. School manuals and curricula are systematically and periodically reviewed to include the values of coexistence, harmony and tolerance.

I should like to note here the decision made by Morocco to teach Jewish history and culture in Arabic to Moroccan students starting in primary school. In addition, in order to promote the just, noble and respectful values of Islam and combat all forms of radicalism and extremism, the Kingdom of Morocco is carrying out various initiatives, including religious reform, an upgrading of religious education and the promotion of cooperation with brotherly and friendly countries, particularly in Africa.

In that connection, on the instruction of King Mohammed VI, Morocco established the Mohammed VI Foundation for African Ulemas and the Mohammed VI Institute for the Training of Imams, Morchidines and Morchidates. The Kingdom provides multidimensional training to hundreds of preachers from a large number of African, Arab, European and Asian countries.

Morocco is also playing a crucial, two-pronged role at the multilateral level. First, we actively contribute to the discussions held on this issue in the various bodies of the United Nations. We also participate in processes aimed at the elaboration and adoption of relevant resolutions at the United Nations. It is on that basis that Morocco submitted to the General Assembly in July 2019 the historic resolution 73/328, on promoting interreligious and intercultural dialogue and tolerance in countering hate speech.

In addition, the General Assembly in July 2021 unanimously adopted resolution 75/309, submitted by Morocco, which proclaims, for the first time in the history of the United Nations, 18 June as the International Day for Countering Hate Speech. That is another illustration of a contribution from Morocco

as a State that builds bridges of tolerance and dialogue among religions, cultures and nations.

In that connection, I wish to invite all present to an event to be organized by Morocco and the United Nations Office on Genocide Prevention and the Responsibility to Protect. The event will commemorate the second anniversary of the International Day for Countering Hate Speech and will be held on Monday at 11 a.m. in the Trusteeship Council Chamber.

Morocco is also proud to have made a substantial contribution to the adoption and implementation of the plans of action, documents and resolutions that form the cornerstone of the various United Nations efforts and initiatives aimed at promoting the culture of peace, the universal values of moderation and tolerance and the fight against all scourges related to discrimination and exclusion. Here I refer in particular to the United Nations Plan of Action to Safeguard Religious Sites; the United Nations Strategy and Plan of Action on Hate Speech; the Marrakesh Declaration on the rights of Religious Minorities in Predominantly Muslim Majority Communities; the Rabat Plan of Action on the prohibition of advocacy of national, racial or religious hatred that constitutes incitement to discrimination, hostility or violence; and the Plan of Action for Religious Leaders and Actors to Prevent Incitement to Violence that Could Lead to Atrocity Crimes.

I would like to underscore here that the Kingdom of Morocco, one of the founding members of the Alliance of Civilizations — whose High Representative, Miguel Ángel Moratinos, we commend — actively participates in global dialogues and conferences and works to foster understanding and cultural enrichment. It spares no effort to promote a dialogue of peace that would allow genuine synergies to flourish within the international community.

My country was pleased to host in November 2022, in the historical city of Fez, the ninth Global Forum of the United Nations Alliance for Civilizations, which highlighted the value of dialogue and tolerance as well as Africa's role as a positive player in the international arena.

The Fez Declaration, which was adopted as the outcome document of that Forum, is a text of particular importance. It sheds light on the fundamental principles of intercultural dialogue, tolerance and international cooperation. The declaration underscores, inter alia, the importance of the central role of education; of women

and young people as mediators in the fight against discrimination and intolerance; of sport as a vector for peace and inclusiveness; of the role of religious leaders in promoting peace, coexistence and social harmony within societies; of reinvigorating multilateralism through the culture of peace; and of countering online hate speech.

I would like to conclude with an excerpt from the statement made by His Majesty the King during the Parliamentary Conference on Interfaith Dialogue: Working Together for Our Common Future, which is currently being held in Marrakesh, from 13 to 15 June:

“We must be aware that if we succeed in creating a fruitful dialogue among religions and civilizations, we will be able to address many of the issues and several of the challenges that threaten the future of our planet and that compromise the ideal of coexistence. As we are all in the same boat, we face the same destiny. Given what is at stake, we must reflect now on the kind of world that we will be bequeathing to future generations. That is as much the responsibility of parliaments, religious institutions and intellectual elites as it is the duty of Governments, civil society and the media”

Mr. Margaryan (Armenia): The promotion and cultivation of dialogue, tolerance and non-discrimination lie at the core of human rights and human dignity, which are indispensable to building peaceful and inclusive societies. At the current difficult time in the history of humankind, fostering a culture that values peace, understanding and cooperation is of crucial importance, as intolerance, exclusion and discrimination, in their various forms and manifestations, continue to create new lines of division and generate conflict in many parts of the world.

Unchecked military buildups and escalation, accompanied by the promulgation of hate speech at the highest political level, persist, including in our immediate neighbourhood.

Armenia welcomed the launch of the United Nations Strategy and Plan of Action on Hate Speech by the Secretary-General in 2019, and we encourage the United Nations Office on Genocide Prevention and the Responsibility to Protect, as the focal point for the implementation of the strategy, to clearly identify instances of hate speech, which constitutes both a trigger and an indicator of the risk of atrocity crimes. As has so often been demonstrated, intolerance and the

cultivation of hate speech against national, ethnic and religious groups, if not properly addressed, can lead to genocide, war crimes and crimes against humanity.

UNESCO plays an important and unique role in promoting the culture of peace and in protecting cultural heritage. Armed conflicts and military action can have a devastating impact on objects of cultural heritage, which are of irreplaceable value to all of humankind as unique expressions of history, identity and cultural memory. Today the milleniums-old Christian Armenian sites in Nagorno-Karabakh are on the verge of total extermination. Armenia's deep concern about the fate of cultural property in Nagorno-Karabakh is also based on the previous history of the total and intentional eradication of the Armenian heritage in Nakhijevan by Azerbaijan.

The destruction of the Armenian cultural heritage has been extensively monitored and reported, including through the use of modern digital technologies. In particular, satellite technology has been increasingly used to monitor and document efforts that seek to destroy or modify cultural sites. Cultural genocide perpetrated on the grounds of ethnic hatred and intent to destroy the traces of the historical and civilizational presence of a particular nation is no longer mere hearsay but can be seen in high-resolution imagery, placing material and factual evidence before the eyes of the international community.

Armenia has consistently requested that a UNESCO fact-finding mission be deployed to Nagorno-Karabakh and adjacent areas in order to help preserve the vast and unique cultural heritage of the region; yet the efforts of international organizations for an independent and impartial assessment of the facts on the ground have been continuously obstructed.

Those who disregard instances of the erasure of cultural heritage in the face of irrefutable evidence thereof for the sake of so-called neutrality need to be reminded that more often than not, State-sponsored policies of hate crimes and violence against culture and history are followed by other kinds of atrocities.

The late Secretary-General Dag Hammarskjöld once said:

“Never, for the sake of peace and quiet, deny your own experience or convictions”.

A culture of peace can thrive only where the right to truth, justice and guarantees of non-recurrence has

been ensured, which makes it a moral imperative for the international community to stand up for the values and convictions that unite us, the people.

Armenia remains committed to a strong and effective multilateral system, with respect for human rights and the rule of law at the heart thereof. We are determined to continue working towards justice, tolerance and non-discrimination, in line with the purposes and principles of the Charter of the United Nations and the values and goals of the Declaration and Programme of Action on a Culture of Peace.

Mr. Gala López (Cuba) (*spoke in Spanish*): My delegation aligns itself with the statement made by the delegation of the Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela on behalf of the Group of Friends in Defence of the Charter of the United Nations

The world continues to face the grave situation caused by the coronavirus disease pandemic, against a backdrop in which the consequences of colonialism and the unjust international economic order had already led to hunger, abject poverty, exclusion, ignorance and inequality, as well as the danger posed by climate change to our very survival.

Despite the fact that that complex state of affairs should have been confronted in a spirit of cooperation and solidarity, instead the flames of conflict are being fanned, and millions and millions continue to be spent on the modernization and scaling up of weapons, including nuclear weapons. Those resources could have been channelled into fostering peace and sustainable development.

Much remains to be done in order to foster and enjoy a genuine culture of peace, a culture that fosters understanding among peoples as well as tolerance and mutual respect in the face of differences. There can be no peace without economic and social development, justice and equity for all. There can be no peace or the strengthening of a culture that fosters it if we do not stringently adhere to the purposes and principles of the Charter of the United Nations and of international law, in particular the prohibition of the use and threat of use of force, non-interference in the domestic affairs of States, respect for sovereignty and the self-determination of peoples.

The advent of a culture of peace is hampered also by the application of unilateral coercive measures as tools of pressure and the promotion of supremacist,

racist and xenophobic ideologies, all of which are scientifically false and morally unacceptable.

My country, which has for more than 60 years been living under constant threat, is well aware of the value of peace. Throughout all those years, Cuba has had to weather State terrorism, military aggression, bacteriological warfare and constant defamation campaigns and campaigns aimed at manipulating Cuban realities, as well as the economic, commercial and financial blockade imposed on us, which represents an act of economic warfare in time of peace and harms the daily lives of the Cuban people.

All that comes from one country. In the face of that policy of systematic hostility, Cuba has always defended its sovereignty and its right to live in peace using the model that our people have freely chosen freely. We are staunchly committed to the implementation of the Declaration and Programme of Action on a Culture of Peace. We reaffirm and defend international law, the Charter of the United Nations and the Proclamation of Latin America and the Caribbean as a Zone of Peace, signed by Heads of State and Government in Havana in 2014.

However, a peaceful world will remain but a pipe dream so long as we fail to prioritize multilateralism and ensure respect for our legitimate differences. The promotion of a culture of peace is the path to follow to bring about a better world, a world that is more just and sustainable for all.

Mr. Ndong Mba (Equatorial Guinea) (*spoke in Spanish*): Our statement is aligned with that made by the representative of the Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela on behalf of the Group of Friends in Defence of the Charter of the United Nations.

First and foremost, I wish to thank the President of the General Assembly, Mr. Csaba Kőrösi, for giving me the opportunity to speak in a debate on the issue of peace, which is of paramount importance for humankind.

I take the floor on behalf of the Republic of Equatorial Guinea to first thank President Kőrösi for having convened this important meeting on the promotion of a culture of peace. Secondly, I wish to congratulate Secretary-General António Guterres for the comprehensive report (A/77/614) that he has produced on the topic in accordance with resolution 76/68, on follow-up to the Declaration and Programme of Action on a Culture of Peace.

Mahatma Gandhi said that there is no path to peace; peace is the path. Indeed, the many challenges currently facing humankind, including armed conflicts, terrorism, tensions among nuclear Powers, pandemics and the effects of climate change, can be tackled by humankind as a whole only if we live in peace — if peace reigns throughout the world

Indeed, enjoying peace and living in a world of peace is the result of promoting a culture of peace, which involves promoting also a culture of non-violence. The culture of peace is a process that requires creating and consolidating an environment that is conducive to dialogue and discussion in order to find solutions to problems and tensions. It is a process that must value all of us, large and small — a process in which all can participate in and influence decision-making.

Consequently, humankind, through institutions such as the United Nations and its decision-making bodies such as the Security Council, must establish the obligation of promoting a culture of peace, an end to violence and the practice of non-violence via education, dialogue and cooperation through multilateralism, as well as through formal education, education based on life skills and cultural awareness programmes, all of which can be used to create and sustain a culture of peace.

The Republic of Equatorial Guinea deems it vital that we reiterate with one voice our commitment to the ideals set out in the United Nations Declaration and Programme of Action on a Culture of Peace. As such, the Government of the Republic of Equatorial Guinea will continue working resolutely to shoulder its share of our collective responsibility to build a more sustainable peace and to contribute to guaranteeing the collective well-being of humankind.

It is in that spirit that His Excellency Mr. Obiang Nguema Mbasogo, President of the Republic of Equatorial Guinea, stated on 5 January 2019, before the Federation of World Peace:

“A people’s greatness is not measured by its geographical dimensions, rather, by its spiritual strength and its humanitarian leadership, by whether it is capable of designing strategies anchored in the search for peace and in the healthy coexistence of nations and peoples as a fundamental and important premise of development.”

That is why the Republic of Equatorial Guinea supports and co-sponsored draft resolution A/77/L.74, introduced by the representative of Bangladesh.

To conclude, allow me to encourage all Member States within the United Nations family to promote the culture of peace. There is no path to peace; peace itself is the path. We must strengthen that peace by bolstering all means and instruments that allow us to resolve disputes peacefully, in a spirit of respect for human dignity, tolerance and non-discrimination. We must strengthen national capacities to implement policies and programmes designed to drastically reduce the share of the global population of all ages living in poverty.

Mrs. Kamboj (India): We welcome the emphasis that the General Assembly has placed on the culture of peace as a driver and enabler of peace and development. We firmly believe that pluralism, tolerance, mutual respect and the diversity of religions and beliefs are the foundation for promoting human fraternity and fostering a culture of peace.

The tradition of welcoming, respecting and honouring all faiths is as old as India itself. The Great Indian philosopher-thinker Swami Vivekananda said:

“We believe not only in universal toleration, but we accept all religions as true”.

It bears reiterating that India considers the entire world as one large, interconnected family. That enduring philosophy has guided our constant interaction and exchange of thoughts with the outside world. In fact, and as many here know, the theme of India's presidency of the Group of 20 is Vasudaiva kutumbakam — one Earth, one family, one future.

Sarva Dharma Sambhava is also a unique concept of Indian secularism that maintains that all religions are inherently good and worthy of respect. That principle of equal respect and treatment for all faiths has been a part of India's ethos for thousands of years. That principle is also integral to the Constitution of India.

We appreciate the efforts of Bangladesh in introducing a draft resolution today on the follow-up to the Declaration and Programme of Action (A/77/L.74), which India is happy to co-sponsor. We firmly believe that the exercise of the right to freedom of opinion and expression and full respect for the freedom to seek, receive and impart information play an important role in promoting pluralism and combating religious intolerance.

Today, as we all know, the world is facing serious threats owing to geopolitical tensions and unequal development. There is a surge in instances of

intolerance, discrimination and acts of violence based on religion or belief. We are deeply concerned with growing manifestations of intolerance, discrimination or violence against followers of both Abrahamic and non-Abrahamic religions.

It is an undeniable fact that contemporary forms of religiophobia are on the rise. These need to be factored into our discussions; we cannot exclude them therefrom for political expediency.

We strongly condemn acts of discrimination or violence motivated by antisemitism, Christianophobia or Islamophobia. We also express deep concern at the growing increase in the number of attacks on religious places, including churches, gurudwaras, monasteries, mosques, temples, synagogues and other religious sites. This is the time for us to work together to strengthen human fraternity and to intensify our efforts in building a culture of peace. We call for strengthened international efforts to foster a global dialogue on the promotion of a culture of peace and reaffirm that interreligious dialogue should be inclusive, broader and encompass all religions and all faiths.

Terrorism, which is a manifestation of intolerance and violence, is the antithesis of all religions and cultures. The world should be concerned by terrorists who use religion to justify these acts and those who support them in this quest. We must adopt zero tolerance against terrorism and violent extremism.

I will also say that effective international cooperation on any of the pillars of the United Nations — human rights, development or peace and security — will remain elusive unless countries recognize and promote the values of democracy, pluralism and the rule of law in the work of the United Nations. I am sure that everyone will agree that it is important to preserve the unitedness of the United Nations by pushing back all attempts to introduce a divisive agenda, particularly in matters related to religion. Member States need to work together to strengthen a real culture of peace and to envision the world as one large family, as does India.

Lastly, and most regrettably, we have heard some deeply distorted and inaccurate, not to mention malicious, remarks from a certain delegation. We have nothing but the utmost sympathy for such a mindset that utters falsehoods repeatedly arising undeniably out of ignorance and a total lack of appreciation for a culture of peace. Unlike the delegation in question, I will not be wasting the time of the Assembly gathered

in this Hall to strengthen multilateralism and foster a dialogue of peace. My only advice to that delegation would be that its members look at the numerous rights of reply we have exercised in the past. There they will find their answer.

As far as my country, India, is concerned, our agenda will always be constructive, progressive and for the greater good of humankind. In the spirit of our civilizational ethos, we remain committed to spreading the message of humanity, democracy, peace and non-violence. We will continue to work with all States Members of the United Nations as well as United Nations entities to promote a culture of peace based on understanding, compassion and respect.

Mr. Montalvo Sosa (Ecuador) (*spoke in Spanish*): Ecuador welcomes the report of the Secretary-General, entitled “Promotion of a culture of peace” (A/77/614), and appreciates the delegation of Bangladesh’s leadership in negotiating the draft resolution entitled “Follow-up to the Declaration and Programme of Action on a Culture of Peace”, contained in document A/77/L.74, which is being considered by the General Assembly and which my country has co-sponsored.

The current situation is worrisome. Peaceful coexistence and development are threatened by the persistence of conflicts, the revival of hate speech, impunity, devastation caused by natural disasters and an unprecedented number of displaced persons and refugees, among other factors. The goal of achieving a sustainable culture of peace seems increasingly distant in the face of new threats that exacerbate the causes of violence, and which are expressed through intolerance, discrimination and misinformation. Some conflicts are magnified by the deployment of speech that incites hatred and intolerance against States, communities belonging to different ethnic, religious, cultural or belief groups, and even against personnel deployed by the United Nations to support conflict resolution, all of which is worrisome.

The use of hate speech and propaganda already proved its destructive capacity in the years leading up to the Second World War. It is imperative to banish their use for good, since narratives construct realities and make us responsible for their consequences. These circumstances, far from discouraging us, should be the main motivation to redouble our efforts to promote a culture of peace that seeks justice, equity and inclusiveness in our societies. We need to renew our commitment to facing the present moment with

processes that allow the participation of women and young people in decision-making.

In accordance with Article 24 of the United Nations Charter, my country currently has the responsibility conferred upon it by the General Assembly to occupy a non-permanent seat on the Security Council. Ecuador’s contribution to the work of the Council is sustained by the principles that guide its foreign policy. Direct dialogue as the best instrument for prevention and coming together and pursuing peace and development are part and parcel of these principles.

The principles of the culture of peace infuse Ecuador’s national legislation. They are, above all, embedded in the conscience of a peaceful people that in recent years has been threatened by transnational organized crime seeking to do away with our democratic institutions. That effort will not succeed because Ecuador is a country committed to peace, sustainable development and democracy.

For all those reasons, on this occasion, we reiterate our concern about the persistence and proliferation of violence and conflicts in various parts of the world. Peace is a positive and dynamic participatory process that requires a spirit of mutual understanding and cooperation.

I would conclude by reiterating our commitment to efforts aimed at establishing a culture of peace, and to supporting the implementation of the Declaration and Programme of Action on a Culture of Peace (resolutions 53/243 A and B) at the local, national, regional and international levels.

Mrs. Alhefeiti (United Arab Emirates) (*spoke in Arabic*): At the outset, I would like to thank the President of the General Assembly for convening today’s important meeting on the culture of peace. This issue is extremely important in the light of the growing challenges and crises that undermine peace efforts around the world, foremost of which are the spread of hate speech, intolerance and growing armed conflict, as well as the impacts of humanitarian crises and climate change.

Confronting those threats requires us to redouble our efforts for promoting a culture of peace. The United Arab Emirates believes that that is the basis for building peaceful and prosperous societies that acknowledge their differences and see them as opportunities for achieving progress and prosperity. In that context, we look forward to adopting the draft resolution submitted

by Bangladesh on a culture of peace (A/77/L.74) and co-sponsored by my country.

We also support the point made by the Secretary-General in his report on today's topic (A/77/614) on the need to harness knowledge and expertise in the light of the escalation of conflicts, so as to promote a culture of peace. That requires us to continue exchanging best practices and exploring ways to overcome challenges that undermine peace and stability, while focusing on the impact of hate speech and extremism against women and girls, in particular.

We stress the need for adopting a proactive and comprehensive approach at the international level to address the threats of racism, intolerance and extremism in all its forms, particularly as extremism incites, exacerbates and prolongs conflicts. That is why the United Arab Emirates has made that issue a top priority, including during its membership in the Security Council. The Council meeting that my country is convening today on the importance of the values of human fraternity in the promotion and sustainability of peace (see S/PV.9346) is a testament to raising awareness about the pivotal role of the values of tolerance and peaceful coexistence in empowering societies to be resilient and build and sustain peace.

The aim of draft resolution A/77/L.74, submitted by the United Arab Emirates and the United Kingdom to the Security Council, to be adopted today, is to address the threats of extremism, intolerance and hate speech and to promote the values of tolerance and peaceful coexistence in conflict situations.

There is no doubt that strengthening partnerships and fostering coordination among all actors, including Governments, the private sector and civil society institutions, are essential for our responses to be effective and comprehensive. Each of us has unique contributions to make to promoting a culture of peace. In that regard, we stress the importance of the full, equal and meaningful participation of women in such efforts, given their pivotal role in building and sustaining peace.

It is also necessary to invest in the potential and ability of young people to create solutions, promote mutual understanding and address their concerns so that extremist and terrorist groups do not exploit them to achieve their goals.

We believe that religious and community leaders have an indispensable role in fostering mutual understanding

among different peoples. In that context, the United Arab Emirates launched the Zayed Award for Human Fraternity, which annually recognizes individuals and organizations that have dedicated their lives to peace and made valuable contributions to that end. Furthermore, the Abrahamic Family House, in Abu Dhabi, provides a venue for promoting mutual understanding, peace and dialogue among people of goodwill.

In line with our belief in the critical role of education in establishing a generation that believes in the values of peaceful coexistence and mutual understanding, the United Arab Emirates has been keen to make tolerance an integral part of its educational system through the launch of several initiatives, including the "On the Path of Zayed" project, which focuses on strengthening communication and positive dialogue among students.

As the Secretary-General emphasized, digital space will be an important issue throughout the next decade. It will require focusing our efforts on addressing the spread of hate speech over social media and disseminating an alternate narrative that promotes human values among peoples.

In conclusion, we look forward to continuing our discussions on a culture of peace, including through the New Agenda for Peace and the Summit of the Future, to be held next year. Despite our important achievements, we must continue to work together to overcome challenges and ensure a better future for the peoples of the world.

Mrs. Mozgovaya (Belarus) (*spoke in Russian*): The delegation of the Republic of Belarus thanks Bangladesh for introducing the draft resolution, and welcomes its adoption by consensus.

Belarus is firmly committed to the ideals of the Declaration and Programme of Action on a Culture of Peace, but regrets to note that, two decades later, the world is still far from embodying that concept.

Today the world is still shaken by conflicts. Old hotbeds of tension remain, and new ones are emerging. Instead of mutual understanding and cooperation, we are witnessing only growing confrontation and mutual accusatory rhetoric. Instead of dialogue on an equal footing, there is a policy of double standards and blatant interference in the internal affairs of States. Instead of respect for cultural diversity and pluralism, there are ongoing attempts by individual countries to impose their paradigm of values and views on others. Instead of promoting sustainable development and strengthening

mutually beneficial trade and economic cooperation, we are unwittingly witnessing the reckless imposition of illegal sanctions.

The Declaration and Programme of Action on a Culture of Peace, adopted by all Member States more than 20 years ago, called for refraining from taking any unilateral measures not in accordance with international law and the Charter of the United Nations and recognized that they hamper the economic and social development of the affected countries, undermine the well-being of their populations and places obstacles to the full enjoyment of human rights.

But today sanctions continue to be almost the only tool in the hands of Western countries directed against those who do not agree with the imposition, by them, of the “rules-based order”. I take this opportunity to once again call on Western countries to reconsider their approaches and lift unilateral and coercive measures that violate international law and undermine the culture of peace at the global level.

After the horrors of war that our people had to live through, a culture of peace is rooted in our consciousness in Belarus, in our genes, enshrined in our cultural code. The concept of a culture of peace is at the heart of our foreign policy. It is no coincidence that many provisions of the Declaration and Programme of Action on a Culture of Peace resonate with the initiative of the President of Belarus to start a global dialogue, leading main international players in the true spirit of San Francisco to build a new system of collective international security.

Today the world needs the decisive will of world leaders to find ways to overcome their differences. Embodying the concept of a culture of peace could be a tool to achieve that end. Committed as we are to the ideals of the Declaration and Programme of Action, Belarus will continue to contribute to strengthening the culture of peace at the global and regional levels.

Mr. Mukashev (Kazakhstan): The delegation of Kazakhstan welcomes the comprehensive report presented by the Secretary-General on the promotion of a culture of peace (A/77/614). The report serves as a testament to our collective commitment to fostering harmony, understanding and unity among nations.

As a multi-ethnic and multireligious country, Kazakhstan places the utmost importance on strengthening interfaith dialogue, both domestically and globally. Since 2003, we have actively fostered interreligious dialogue by hosting the triennial Congress

of Leaders of World and Traditional Religions. The most recent Congress, the seventh in the series, was held in September. We were honoured to have the participation of esteemed figures such as the Grand Imam of Al-Azhar, Ahmed Al-Tayeb, His Holiness Pope Francis and other prominent religious leaders who delivered powerful messages of peace to the world.

As an outcome of that Congress, a significant and highly detailed Final Declaration was adopted, encompassing principles of religious pluralism, mutual respect, non-discrimination and equality. Participants of the Congress initiated the issuance of the Final Declaration as an official document of the seventy-seventh session of the General Assembly, serving as a guiding framework for Governments, political leaders and international organizations in their pursuit of interfaith harmony.

All of those initiatives align with the Organization’s concept of the culture of peace, which aims to promote dialogue and understanding among diverse cultures, religions and nations as a means to achieve sustainable peace and security.

In that spirit, the delegation of Kazakhstan is pleased to co-sponsor the draft resolution on this item today. We also commend the delegation of Bangladesh for its transparent and diligent efforts in facilitating the text of the draft resolution and successfully leading the negotiation process to reach a consensus.

Mr. Aliyev (Azerbaijan): At the outset, I would like to thank the President for convening this meeting and for his important opening remarks.

We are grateful to the delegation of Bangladesh for facilitating the negotiations on draft resolution A/77/L.74, entitled “Follow-up to the Declaration and Programme of Action on a Culture of Peace”, submitted annually, which my country, Azerbaijan, has sponsored.

We also thank the Secretary-General for his report, contained in the document A/77/614, on the promotion of a culture of peace submitted pursuant to resolution 76/68.

Azerbaijan attaches great importance to the promotion of a culture of peace, paying particular attention to encouraging intercultural and interreligious dialogue at the national and international levels and successfully implementing various initiatives to that end.

As the Secretary-General informed in his report, in Azerbaijan, UN-Women and the Department of Political and Peacebuilding Affairs, in partnership with the Government of Azerbaijan, put forward a plan for a series of intergenerational forums on women and peace and security to raise awareness about gender mainstreaming in post-conflict reconstruction, access to sustained and legal livelihoods, women's participation in spheres of decision-making and advocacy for endorsement of the country's national action plan on the implementation of Security Council resolution 1325 (2000). The report also mentioned the participation of women and youth civil society representatives from Azerbaijan in the UN-Women-organized online consultations on the theme entitled "Looking beyond 2020: Advancing Women, peace and security in Eastern Partnership countries".

As the Secretary-General highlighted in his report, a culture of peace is central to the founding mission of the United Nations. Indeed, intercultural and interreligious dialogue remains one of the important avenues within the broader objectives of peacebuilding, sustaining peace and reconciliation and is essential for tackling the root causes of violence and conflict.

However, hate propaganda, disinformation and the policies aimed at sowing dissension on religious and racial grounds, building mono-ethnic societies and advocating the ideas of ethnic incompatibility, dehumanization and racial superiority, continue to fuel identity-based intolerance, destabilize societies and undermine peaceful coexistence.

Attempts to weaponize the past and promote fabricated historical narratives serve the same purpose, resulting in generations growing up with a deep sense of hatred and intolerance.

Impunity for serious violations of international law remains one of the major impediments to peace, justice and reconciliation in some parts of the world.

It is high time to translate the right words into real actions. As we speak in this Hall, people are dying in conflicts or are being blown up by mines in peacetime, including in my country, Azerbaijan.

We concur with the Secretary-General that the work of the United Nations on a culture of peace can be seen as a natural support for the New Agenda for Peace and its role to promote peace and prevent conflict.

The fundamentally flawed and false allegations made by the representative of Armenia earlier at this meeting reveal the extent to which hatred, intolerance and falsehood dominate in his country's discourse and the serious threat that it poses to regional peace, security and stability.

It is ironic to hear accusations of hatred and discrimination on ethnic grounds from Armenia, where the dehumanization and identity denial of Azerbaijanis is so prevalent that anti-Azerbaijani stereotypes are taught to Armenian children in school from an early age and have expanded into a widely accepted view that Azerbaijanis are ethnically incompatible with Armenians. At the heart of the real objectives and policies of Armenia is a long-standing racist ideology, which seeks to unify all Armenians within a single, mono-ethnic State.

That is exactly what Armenia tried to accomplish by expelling all of the more than 200,000 Azerbaijanis from their historical homeland in Armenia, further unleashing aggression against Azerbaijan and occupying and ethnically cleansing a large portion of my country's sovereign territory.

Over more than 30 years of conflict and occupation, Armenia subjected Azerbaijani cultural heritage in the formerly occupied territories to large-scale plunder, destruction and vandalism. The facts are really shocking and unprecedented. Suffice it to mention just a few. Thus, out of 67 mosques in the formerly occupied territories 64 were destroyed. The deliberate use of mosques as pens for pigs and cows during the occupation was a potent and symbolic action intended as a particular insult. Over 900 cemeteries in those territories were either destroyed or desecrated. They were targeted deliberately owing to their familial, historical and cultural importance to our people.

Moreover, despite the end of the war in the fall of 2020, in blatant disregard for the binding measure indicated by the International Court of Justice on 7 December 2021 ordering Armenia to take all necessary measures to prevent the incitement and promotion of racial hatred, including by organizations and private persons in its territory, targeted at persons of Azerbaijani national or ethnic origin, various organizations operating in Armenia continue to incite anti-Azerbaijani hatred with total impunity.

Despite the devastating consequences of the aggression unleashed against my country and

unspeakable atrocities and sufferings that our people have endured, it was Azerbaijan that, following the end of the war, genuinely proposed to Armenia normalizing inter-State relations. That initiative has been widely supported by the international community.

Azerbaijan remains fully committed to the objectives of a peaceful, secure, stable and prosperous region and will continue its efforts towards advancing post-conflict peacebuilding, reintegration and development in the region. We are keen to further contribute to the culture of peace, strengthen the legal order, advance the prevention agenda, ensure accountability and enhance dialogue and global solidarity.

Mr. Rizal (Malaysia): Malaysia aligns itself with the statement delivered by the representative of Brunei Darussalam on behalf of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations and wishes to add the following remarks in its national capacity.

At the outset, we thank the Secretary-General for his report on the promotion of a culture of peace, as contained in document A/77/614.

Our meeting today is an opportune moment to reflect on the recently concluded International Decade for the Rapprochement of Cultures and where we stand at this juncture.

Regrettably, 24 years after the Declaration and Programme of Action on a Culture of Peace was adopted, the paramount objective of peace appears to be further out of reach. Many parts of the world are currently embroiled in conflict, unrest and upheaval, both recent and long-standing. The peaceful settlement of disputes is being cast aside in favour of the escalation of tensions. We are living in volatile times not seen since the end of the Second World War.

Further compounding the situation are acts of terror and hate crimes emanating from racial and religious discrimination, as well as xenophobia. While we have seen some efforts to increase awareness and address those concerning trends, including through the proclamation of international days, the level of vigour in combating some of those phenomena, for example, Islamophobia, remains lacklustre.

The dire situation we face today is a case in point of the importance of cultivating a culture of peace. It is imperative that respect for peace and non-violence, intercultural dialogue and social inclusion are fostered globally. Peaceful coexistence among nations, peoples,

faiths and cultures must be vigorously promoted. The culture of peace is an important dimension of international commitment towards the promotion of mutual understanding and cooperation with a view to achieving global peace.

The promotion of interactions among States, as well as peoples, from diverse faiths, cultures and values is imperative to develop understanding, acceptance and appreciation of our distinctiveness. That would in turn contribute to strengthening global peace and security, a prerequisite for sustainable economic and social development. As a multicultural, multiracial and multireligious country, Malaysia strongly believes that mutual understanding, respect and tolerance among religions, cultures and peoples form the bedrock of the culture of peace.

We also believe that embracing and adopting the culture of peace must begin at home. In line with that spirit, the Honourable Prime Minister of Malaysia introduced the Malaysia Madani concept, centred on six core values, namely, sustainability, prosperity, innovation, respect, trust and compassion, as an expression of Malaysia's desire to create a humanistic nation based on its civilizational values.

The status quo is unsustainable. The cultivation of a culture of peace globally is important now more than ever. It is imperative that we cast aside inflammatory rhetoric and instead embrace meaningful dialogue. Every layer of society, from Governments to the individual person, share the collective responsibility of promoting and upholding global peace.

I end with the words of Ralph Waldo Emerson,

"Peace cannot be achieved through violence; it can only be attained through understanding."

Mr. Alrowaiei (Bahrain) (*spoke in Arabic*): At the outset, I would like to express my thanks to the delegation of Bangladesh for its efforts pertaining to the facilitation of draft resolution A/77/L.74 on a culture of peace.

The Kingdom of Bahrain stresses the importance of promoting a culture of peace through dialogue and mediation to prevent conflicts and create the conditions necessary for resolving the differences by peaceful and sustainable means and by promoting preventive diplomacy.

The Kingdom of Bahrain, under His Majesty King Hamad bin Isa Al Khalifa and with the support of His

Royal Highness Prince Salman bin Hamad Al Khalifa, Crown Prince and Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Bahrain, is proud of its civilized and cultural history based on tolerance and peaceful coexistence. We support the efforts of the international community to promote security and peace in view of establishing relations among nations and cultures based on friendliness, understanding, dialogue and respect for others along with the tenets of Islam, the provisions of international law and the commitment to maintain the rights and dignity of human beings without discrimination based on race, gender or religion.

The Kingdom of Bahrain is proud to celebrate annually the International Day of Conscience on 5 April, which was adopted by the General Assembly in resolution 73/329 and stresses the importance of international conscience for the collective efforts of the international community in achieving peace, tolerance and saving peoples from the scourge of wars and conflicts while rejecting violence and hatred and establishing a safe and sustainable world characterized by harmony, peaceful coexistence and brotherhood.

Since its foundation in 2018, the King Hamad Global Centre for Peaceful Coexistence has launched many international initiatives and organized international conferences for dialogue among religions and cultures, the most recent of which was the Bahrain Forum for Dialogue: East and West for Human Coexistence, which coincided with the visit of His Holiness the Pope and His Eminence Sheikh Al-Azhar Al-Sharif, along with establishing the King Hamad International Award for Dialogue and Peaceful Coexistence and many other awards in the service of humankind and in support of sustainable development, enabling women and empowering the youth.

The Kingdom of Bahrain calls on countries to adopt an international convention to criminalize hate speech based on religions, sectarians and discrimination. We should work collectively to spread a culture of peace, promote brotherhood and strengthen friendliness among nations. Those values should be incorporated into our curricula along with our religious, cultural and sports activities.

In conclusion, our continued efforts to promote a culture of peace and dialogue among various religions and cultures will help us to overcome ignorance and misunderstanding which threaten social cohesion and peace and stability in our interrelated, open and multicultural world.

The Acting President: We have heard the last speaker in the debate on this item.

We shall now proceed to consider draft resolution A/77/L.74.

I now give the floor to the representative of the Secretariat.

Ms. Sharma (Department for General Assembly and Conference Management): I should like to announce that, since the submission of draft resolution A/77/L.74 and in addition to the delegations listed in the document, the following countries have also become sponsors of the draft resolution: Afghanistan, Algeria, Bhutan, the Plurinational State of Bolivia, Brazil, Bulgaria, Burkina Faso, Burundi, Cameroon, Chad, Chile, Colombia, Costa Rica, Côte d'Ivoire, Denmark, Ecuador, Egypt, El Salvador, Equatorial Guinea, Eritrea, Ethiopia, Fiji, the Gambia, Greece, Guatemala, Guyana, Japan, Kenya, Kuwait, the Lao People's Democratic Republic, Lebanon, Luxembourg, Malawi, Malaysia, Maldives, Mauritius, Mexico, Mongolia, Namibia, Nigeria, North Macedonia, Norway, Oman, Palau, Panama, Paraguay, Peru, Philippines, Portugal, the Republic of Korea, Rwanda, Saint Vincent and the Grenadines, Saudi Arabia, Senegal, Serbia, Sierra Leone, South Africa, the State of Palestine, Suriname, Sweden, Timor-Leste, Trinidad and Tobago, Türkiye, Tuvalu, Uganda, the United Arab Emirates, Uruguay, Uzbekistan, Viet Nam, Yemen and Zambia.

The Acting President: The Assembly will now take a decision on draft resolution A/77/L.74, entitled "Follow-up to the Declaration and Programme of Action on a Culture of Peace".

May I take it that the Assembly wishes to adopt draft resolution A/77/L.74?

Draft resolution A/77/L.74 was adopted (resolution 77/296).

The Acting President: Before giving the floor for explanations of position after adoption, I would like to remind delegations that explanations are limited to 10 minutes and should be made by delegations from their seats.

Mr. Pine (United States of America): The United States strongly believes in encouraging a culture of peace through the promotion of justice, democracy and human rights, as well as by rejecting violence and addressing the root causes of conflict. In recognition of those values, we support resolution 77/296. We thank

Bangladesh for its leadership on the text and for its work to ensure that it reflects the views of all delegations.

Mr. Ghadirkhomi (Islamic Republic of Iran): I take the floor to explain the position of the Islamic Republic of Iran regarding resolution 77/296, which the General Assembly just adopted.

My Government recognized the importance of the Declaration and Programme of Action on a Culture of Peace, adopted by the General Assembly on 13 September 1999, which served as a basis for the emerging international understanding regarding the promotion of a culture of peace and non-violence for the benefit of all humankind. Various subsequent resolutions have contributed to the implementation of the Declaration since then. In that understanding, my delegation joined the consensus on today's adoption of resolution 77/296. However, we regret that despite numerous requests by Member States, some new language was included in the resolution without the consent of all delegations.

In that regard, I would like to address the issue of the fifth preambular paragraph and the references made to resolution 76/250. Our position regarding that particular resolution remains valid, as we stated during its adoption at the Assembly's plenary meeting of 20 January 2022 (see A/76/PV.55). My delegation strongly believes that this resolution is not relevant to the implementation of the Declaration and Programme of Action. We would also like to share our concerns regarding the proliferation of repetitive and irrelevant references to national priorities in the context of resolutions related to a culture of peace, which negatively undermine the implementation of resolution 53/243 and distance us from our common goals enshrined in the Declaration.

The Acting President: We have heard the last speaker in explanation of position after adoption.

The General Assembly has thus concluded this stage of its consideration of agenda item 14.

Agenda item 7 (continued)

Organization of work, adoption of the agenda and allocation of items

The Acting President: Members will recall that at its 3rd plenary meeting, on 16 September 2022, the General Assembly decided to allocate agenda item 48 to the Special Political and Decolonization Committee

(Fourth Committee) to enable the Assembly to take action expeditiously on draft resolution A/77/L.75.

May I take it that the Assembly wishes to consider agenda item 48 directly in plenary meeting and proceed immediately to its consideration?

It was so decided (decision 77/505 B).

Agenda item 48 (continued)

Comprehensive review of the whole question of peacekeeping operations in all their aspects

Draft resolution (A/77/L.75)

The Acting President: I now give the floor to the representative of India to introduce draft resolution A/77/L.75.

Mrs. Kamboj (India): I have the honour to introduce draft resolution A/77/L.75, entitled "Memorial wall for fallen United Nations peacekeepers", submitted by Bangladesh, Cameroon, Canada, China, Denmark, Egypt, France, Indonesia, Ireland, Jordan, Morocco, Nepal, Nigeria, Pakistan, Rwanda, the United States of America, Zambia and my own country, India. I would also like to thank all 190 delegations that have sponsored the initiative and to invite the rest to join as well.

For 75 years, United Nations peacekeeping has been one of the most important tools for mitigating conflict and promoting peace and security around the globe. During that period, more than 1 million men and women from 125 countries have served in 71 peacekeeping missions worldwide. Even today, more than 80,000 peacekeepers are serving in various conflict zones, enduring harsh conditions and risking their lives to keep the peace. Keeping peace, however, has not been without its cost. In those 75 years, more than 4,200 peacekeepers have laid down their lives in service of the Blue Flag. Those brave men and women came from different parts of the world, practiced different faiths and followed different cultures. They were united by their commitment to the cause of peace, their spirit of selfless sacrifice, their professionalism and their resolve to bring succour to lives riven by conflict. Those peacekeepers made the supreme sacrifice in the pursuit of mandates that we, as Member States, asked them to carry out. It is therefore our bounden responsibility to ensure that their sacrifice is not forgotten and that their memories are honoured.

For that very purpose, since 2015 the Special Committee on Peacekeeping Operations, known

as the C-34, has been consistently recommending the establishment of a memorial wall for fallen peacekeepers at United Nations Headquarters. India, as the largest troop- and police-contributing country, is deeply committed to that cause. During the World Leaders' Summit on Peacekeeping held in New York in 2015, the Prime Minister of India said,

"I would like to pay homage to the peacekeepers who have laid down their lives in defending the highest ideals of the United Nations. It would be most fitting if the proposed memorial wall to the fallen peacekeepers was created quickly. India stands ready to contribute, including financially, to that objective".

The establishment of the memorial wall at a prominent location at United Nations Headquarters is therefore of the utmost importance for all of us. It will be a testimony to the importance that we as the United Nations attach to peacekeeping and our peacekeepers. It will be a source of solace for the near and dear ones of the brave hearts who have made the supreme sacrifice, as well as for their serving comrades and colleagues. It will be a constant reminder not only of the sacrifices of the fallen but of the cost of our decisions.

We are conscious that peacekeeping is a shared endeavour, and many Member States may want to contribute to the overall endeavour of establishing a memorial wall. At the same time, it should be a burden on no one. Draft resolution A/77/L.75 therefore stipulates that the memorial wall should be funded entirely from voluntary contributions from interested Member States. The draft resolution also recommends that once established, the memorial wall should be given due respect through inclusion during peacekeeping-related events, especially the solemn ceremonies conducted on the International Day of United Nations Peacekeepers.

We are aware that the draft resolution is just the beginning of the endeavour. There are many challenges before us and many decisions to be taken to ensure that the wall is established in a manner befitting its sanctity and purpose. But importantly, the draft resolution has also served to unite us in the endeavour. It is therefore our belief that together we will prevail over any obstacles and establish the wall within the next three years, as stipulated in the draft resolution.

In conclusion, India would like to thank all sponsors for their support to the draft resolution. We would especially like to thank the delegations of Bangladesh, Cameroon, Canada, China, Denmark, Egypt, France, Indonesia, Ireland, Jordan, Morocco, Nepal, Nigeria, Pakistan, Rwanda, the United States and Zambia for their effort and support, which have led to the submission of the draft resolution. We are also most grateful to the Secretariat for its constant assistance in all technical matters related to the submission of the draft text.

Peacekeepers are not born; they are forged through the crucible of sacrifice. Their unwavering commitment and selfless acts pave the way for a world in which peace must triumph over conflict. We will now deeply appreciate the adoption of the draft resolution on "Memorial wall for fallen United Nations peacekeepers".

The Acting President: We shall now proceed to consider draft resolution A/77/L.75.

I give the floor to the representative of the Secretariat.

Ms. Sharma (Department for General Assembly and Conference Management): I should like to announce that, since the submission of the draft resolution and in addition to the delegations listed in the document, the following countries have also become sponsors of A/77/L.75: Brunei Darussalam, the Congo, Sao Tome and Principe. The State of Palestine has also become a sponsor of the draft resolution.

The Acting President: The Assembly will now take a decision on draft resolution A/77/L.75, entitled "Memorial Wall for fallen United Nations peacekeepers". May I take it that the Assembly decides to adopt draft resolution A/77/L.75?

Draft resolution A/77/L.75 was adopted (resolution 77/297).

The Acting President: The General Assembly has thus concluded this stage of its consideration of agenda item 48.

The meeting rose at 12.45 p.m.